

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 887

By McNally

A RESOLUTION to support Tennessee's response to the United States Department of Energy Request for Information on Nuclear Lifecycle Innovation Campuses.

WHEREAS, Tennesseans have always answered America's call; embodying a "Volunteer Spirit" passed down from generation to generation, we stand ready to answer President Trump's charge to unleash the domestic nuclear industrial base and secure American energy dominance; and

WHEREAS, on January 28, 2026, the United States Department of Energy invited states to host Nuclear Lifecycle Innovation Campuses—integrated hubs integrating the full nuclear value chain—that could each attract up to \$50 billion dollars in private investment, create tens of thousands of jobs, and begin initial operations as early as 2027; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee opened the Atomic Age with the Manhattan Project in Oak Ridge and has never left the frontier of nuclear innovation, sustaining more than eighty years of unbroken service to the nation through Oak Ridge National Laboratory, the Y-12 National Security Complex, and a nuclear environmental cleanup project recognized as a "remarkable achievement" by the United States Environmental Protection Agency and positioning the nation for future nuclear advancements; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee is today the number-one state in the nation for nuclear energy development, home to more than 230 nuclear companies, the top nuclear engineering programs in the country, and a workforce that includes various professions, from the research scientist to the welder—an ecosystem that has attracted more than \$8 billion dollars in nuclear investment from around the world; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee is the location of the nation's first early site permitted for a small modular reactor (the first SMR for the American grid), which is backed by a \$400-million federal award; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee hosts the first new reactor type licensed by the Nuclear Regulatory Commission in over fifty years, which is now under construction in Oak Ridge; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee also hosts the first new fuel facilities licensed by the Nuclear Regulatory Commission in over fifty years, with one facility set to become the first-ever Category II nuclear fuel facility in the United States; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee has been chosen as the location for the first privately funded nuclear fuel recycling facility in American history; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee is home to the only commercial uranium enrichment centrifuge manufacturing plant in the country, one of the largest private uranium enrichment investments in the nation's history; and

WHEREAS, while Tennessee is a demonstrated leader in accelerating deployment of commercial nuclear power, the nuclear activities in this State also result in critical national security and defense achievements. Public and private sector investments and partnerships have placed Tennessee at the heart of domestic enrichment supply chain development, strengthening national security and fueling energy dominance; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee is at the vanguard of the development of commercial fusion, moving forward as an Agreement State with a foundational regulatory framework developed in collaboration with the industry and financially supported by Governor Bill Lee and the General Assembly; this framework is both flexible and protective of health, safety, and security, while also substantially contributing to national and international fusion advancements; and

WHEREAS, Governor Bill Lee and the General Assembly have invested \$70 million in the Tennessee Nuclear Energy Supply Chain Investment Fund to build this nuclear ecosystem,

with an additional \$25 million proposed in the 2026 budget, and these State dollars have catalyzed billions in private capital—proof that Tennessee does not just welcome nuclear energy but actively builds the conditions for its success; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee is, by any measure, the most prepared State in the Union to host a Nuclear Lifecycle Innovation Campus; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we urge Governor Bill Lee to submit a comprehensive response to the Department of Energy Request for Information on Nuclear Lifecycle Innovation Campuses no later than April 1, 2026, pledge our full support for Tennessee's candidacy, and declare our intent to take any legislative action necessary to position Tennessee as the host of this campus.